

The Mirage of the Middle East: Constructing Identity throughout History

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Introduction

This essay is a history of a mirage. Throughout the 20th Century, scholars of skeptical and perceptive minds have observed how cultural identities we are familiar with today were, in fact, fairly recent inventions. Benedict Anderson, in his *Imagined Communities*, observed that nationalism and nation-states came into being with the advent of the industrial revolution and mass media. Anderson saw a nation-state as a social construct, a collective imagination of a people with shared language and culture.¹ But the most ancient of all social constructs in the history of political and cultural consciousness must be the Middle East. No one can agree on where it starts or where it ends. It's vaguely in the east, full of barbarism and terrorism, so backward compared to the industrial and secular West. But its history as a social construct goes back thousands of years before the modern era. The idea of "Orient", as Edward Said has put it, has been utilized by various authors and artists as both an immortal enemy and an alluring paradise throughout history. Starting with the ancient Greeks and their victory over the Persians, people in and outside of the region have tried to construct their identity through the Middle East.

The idea of the "Orient" was developed by authors and artists of the so-called "West" during the modern era. Although the East is commonly referred to as East Asia colloquially today, these authors from the 18th to the 20th Century meant the Middle East when they were writing on the Orient. And the West, or the *Occident*, here is a collection of Western European nations such as Britain and France.² Throughout the introduction of his preliminary work, *Orientalism*, literary critic Edward Said posits multiple definitions of the phenomenon he coined as "Orientalism". Firstly, the root of Orientalism originates from the West's notion of the Orient—that is, the idea of forming Western identities via contrasting the values of two distinct worlds, and elevating themselves as a superior civilization. In Said's words, Orientalism is the most base distinction between East and West as the starting point for different means of literature. When he introduces the general synopsis of his work, Said states, "European culture gained in strength and identity by setting

itself off against the Orient as a sort of surrogate and even underground self.³ Presenting multiple definitions of Orientalism, branching out to different aspects of the phenomenon, Said implies that Orientalism consists of multiple meanings depending on the context. Nevertheless, he ascertains that the notion of Orientalism holds great significance in understanding the mirage as well as the reality of the Middle East.

Orientalism doesn't end on a mere definition; instead, the idea holds history and inherent meaning that incorporates "thoughts, imagery, and vocabulary that have given it reality and presence in and for the West". Originally, in the late 18th Century, Orientalism emerged as European scholars began to dedicate themselves to studying the cultures, languages, and literatures of "the East". This academic devotion, while initially scholarly, often involved the comparative approach of two geographical entities, "the West and the East", foreshadowing the gradual advent of Said's definition. By any means, this vague notion requires "a number of reasonable qualifications" in order to constitute Said's definition of Orientalism. Firstly, we shouldn't conclude that "the Orient was essentially an idea, or a creation with no corresponding reality". In Disraeli's novel *Tancred*, for example, the Orient or Orientalism had very little contribution to the story or the overall content of the novel, indicating tacit acknowledgment of its oriental setting. Nonetheless, followed by his critique of *Tancred*, Said posits that the internal consistency of Orientalism and its ideas about the Orient is the essence shown through the text; that is, Disraeli's statement about the East contributes to the created consistency of the notion of Orientalism. In addition, one must acknowledge the importance of the power dynamics between the Occident and the Orient during the modern era when comprehending the ideas, cultures, and histories of Orientalism. The relationship between the Occident and Orient is an interchanging level of domination. Because of this power dynamic, it was Western authors who spoke on behalf of the orientals, robbing them of their own agency and story. With no agency of their own in an asymmetrical power dynamic, the description of the Orient is dictated by the Western author. Finally, one should not believe that Orientalism simply depicts myths or fraudulent ideas discoursed by Western civilizations. Instead, Said argues that Orientalism reflects the greater lens of Western consciousness imbued in their works or studies on the Middle East. Nevertheless, one must revere and accept the strength of Orientalist discourse, comprising its redoubtable durability as well as its close adherence to the

enabling socio-economic and political institutions. As such, Orientalism is a firmly established body of theory and practice that holds rich, solid history rather than a European fantasy surrounding the Orient.⁴ Orientalism is thus an unconscious expression of the Western authors' identity through its contrast with "the East", rather than an authentic description of the Middle East. This "Mirage" of the Middle East expresses various notions of identity depending on the period, power dynamic, and material gains. Although Said's critique of Orientalism was limited in scope to modern Western literature, the observations he made in his titular volume can be well applied throughout the history of the Middle East.

This essay will cover three case studies to examine how the idea of the Middle East came to be and how it changed over time: ancient, medieval, and modern. Since Said posits the origin of Orientalism in Aeschylus's *The Persians*, the first case study will examine how the ancient Greeks used the idea of the Middle East, then ruled by the Persian Empire, in their literature and art. The second case study is the Mongol rule of the Middle East and their own construction of a new identity and kingship, forging their own "mirage" of legitimacy in the region. And finally, the modern case study will look at how the Gulf states are taking advantage of the idea of the Middle East and the imagery in advertisements.

Greece and Persia

Said attributes the earliest examples of Orientalism in Western consciousness to the ancient Greeks, after their triumph over the Persian Empire. The discussion of this Greek perception of the Persians and the wider "Eastern" world will be crucial to understanding how the mirage of the Middle East had its inception in the ancient world. Greeks, particularly Athens, provide us with a wide range of perspectives on the Persians and the Persian empire, ruled by the Achaemenid dynasty. Amongst the modern scholarship, the specialists focus their lenses on "dialogues of alterity and imperialism". Magnifying the Classical period, Greeks differentiated themselves from the rest of the world, calling other cultures "Barbarians". This ideology gradually branched out as a form of Greek alterity and Orientalism. Expressed through various ancient Greek artworks as well as different scholars, the Greeks' biased lens towards themselves and the others reveals "our contemporary abhorrence

of imperialism, ‘the devastating consequences of alterity in history’ and the damaging nature of ‘orientalist’ perceptions, as much as they widen our knowledge of Athenian perceptions of Achaemenid Iran”. Nonetheless, these perspectives are not holistically negative. The Greeks embraced the Achaemenid art style, adopted Persian attire and items, implying the possibility of the Greeks looking up to the Achaemenid Empire as their cultural model. In fact, in *Athens and Persia in the Fifth Century BC*, Archaeologist Margaret Miller suggested that the Greeks’ message in their artworks not only signified their alterity and empire, but may have reflected the radical change in Athenian society arising from the post-war political climate and the firm establishment of the Athenian democracy.⁵ Miller’s interpretation of Greek vase paintings portraying the Persians highlights the ambivalent nature between “the rhetoric of alterity and the copying of Achaemenid forms that supports the idea that the negative perspectives are more ideology than reality”.⁶ As such, Classical Greeks’ ideology towards other cultures, mostly the Persians, wasn’t a one-sided, blunt imperialism, but rather a collection of contradictions that emerged from the conflict in their identity. Two authors best exemplify this conflict between the two identities and their literary construction: Aeschylus and Herodotus.

The Greeks, in the form of their famous plays, visual art, and writings, left us many windows into how they perceived the world and their Persian foes. Just 8 years after the Battle of Salamis, where the Athenian-led Greek fleet destroyed the invading Persian fleet, Aeschylus wrote the tragic play, *The Persians*, on the war from the perspectives of the defeated Persians. The dichotomy between the two continents, Europe and Asia, is prominently featured throughout the *Persians*. In the words of Persian characters themselves, Asia is described as despotic and submissive to the rule of their king, the Persian king Xerxes, while Europe is free and independent. Edith Hall’s *Inventing the Barbarian* posited Aeschylus’s *Persians* as the earliest attestment of the Greek-Barbarian dichotomy that reflects the growing ideological need for Athens. Hall points out that the term *barbarian* was rarely used in mainland Greece until after the Persian invasions. *Persians* was written when Athens was firmly a democracy, and the leader of the Delian League. In order to organize the previously independent Greek city-states into a panhellenic league under Athenian rule, inventing the corollary of the barbarians, the common enemy of the Greeks, became necessary.⁷ With this historical background, the *mirage* of

the Middle East, in this case the Persian Empire, crystallizes as a Greek invention. Said has noticed this mirage of the Greeks just as Hall did. Said comments that the Persians, or Asians in general, featured in Greek theatrics are European constructions, meant to serve as the qualitative opposites to the Greeks. He uses Aeschylus's dichotomy between the Greeks and Persians as an example of his notion of contrast between the Orient and the Occident. The Greeks are independent-minded and masculine, while the Persians are submissive and effeminate. The Greeks fight with spears in melee combat, while the Persians shoot arrows from a distance.⁸ The Persians became the opposite of everything the Greeks wanted to be.

Herodotus, the so-called "father of history", also used a similar dichotomy in his eminent *Histories* to pit the "East" and the "West" against one another. In his works, the Greeks are described as much more heavily armored and braver than the Persians, making them much more effective in melee combat than the "cowardly" Persians who relied on missile attacks. This weakness of the Persian military is a common theme in *Histories*. When Aristagoras, tyrant of Miletus, urged the Spartan king Cleomenes to come and liberate the Ionians from the Persian rule, he described a fantastical image of the "East" as a wealthy and fertile land full of rare minerals and fruits, to urge Cleomenes to strike these Persian territories. And the rulers of this land, the Persians, are said to be easy to defeat due to their barbarous customs.⁹ And at the battle of Plataea in 479 BCE, Herodotus once again depicted the Persians as unskilled and inexperienced compared to the Greeks. The Greeks are heavily armored and are skilled in melee combat, while the Persians are described as:

"Now the Persians were neither the less valorous nor the weaker; but they had no armour, and moreover they were unskilled and no match for their adversaries in craft; they would rush out singly and in tens or in groups great or small, hurling themselves on the Spartans and so perishing."¹⁰

Konijnendijk's reassessment of the previous Century of scholarship on the battle of Plataea refutes this dichotomy of the strong Greeks and weak Persians in Herodotus' writing. He criticized modern historians for regurgitating the dichotomy of Aeschylus and Herodotus when writing a military history of ancient Greek and Persian armies, especially their infantry. Despite providing the richest description of Plataea, Konijnendijk points out the environment in

which Herodotus was writing his *histories*. He was writing and presenting his work in Athens to the Athenian audience. This alone makes Herodotus a problematic source for the historical description of the battle, since there's no doubt that Herodotus would have embellished his writing in order to appeal to the Athenian audience.¹¹

Another glaring problem with Herodotus' description of Plataea is that he contradicts his own previous descriptions of Persian infantry. At Pleatea, Herodotus describes the Persian infantry as "fighting naked" due to their lack of proper armor. Konijnendijk refers back to the earlier depiction of the Persian army by Herodotus that contradicts his narrative of the Battle of Plataea, where the Persians are armed with cuirass armor and helmets.¹² In order to glorify the Greek victory over the Persians even further, Herodotus also heavily inflated the number of Persian soldiers at Plataea to three hundred thousand, another contradiction to his later description where he reported that the Persian army was 'not much greater' than the Greeks.¹³ The weak and effeminate Persians, who lose to the Greeks in close, melee combat due to their lack of armor and skill, are another mirage that glorified the victorious Greeks at the expense of the Persian invaders. Konijnendijk's reassessment of the Battle of Plataea reveals how the battle was lost not because of the Persians' lack of armor or skill, but due to "a combination of logistical, tactical and psychological factors".¹⁴

Notwithstanding this Greek antagonism towards the Persians, the invasion of the Persian empire still left an immense cultural impact on Greece, especially when it comes to constructing their own identity in ancient Athens. Persian culture was still a powerful influence on the Greeks despite the Persians' defeat and retreat out of Europe. In fact, this influence was evident throughout Classical Greek culture, showing the gradual shift in their identity. For example, attributed to the painter of the Oxford Brygos, *Greek Hoplite Fighting a Persian Warrior* presents a warfare scene encapsulating the hostile tension between the Greeks and the Persians. In an aristocratic milieu, the Greeks and Persians are fighting one by one in a heroic fashion, but always resulting in the Greeks being victorious over their Persian foes. The Persians in Greek vase paintings slowly begin to morph in the 460s, as they become less and less of a challenge to the Greek defenders and are reduced to pathetic figures. The Basel Calyx-Krater exemplifies this "devolution" of the Persians as

powerless, cowardly enemies, with the Persian holding a broken bow, “a weapon—an unmanly one—that kills from afar”, fleeing from the heroic Greeks. Further ridicule of the Persians came with the twist of Persian ideals. Greek authors such as Herodotus described the importance of equestrianism among the Persians, where young Persian boys are taught to “ride, master the bow, and tell the truth” at a young age. The Greeks would twist the importance of horses in Persian culture by replacing their mounts with “lesser” animals. Created around the late 5th Century, the lekythos of the *Persian King Riding on a Camel* provides us with a subversion of Persian iconography. The lekythos depicts the Great King riding on a camel, instead of a horse, surrounded by his attendants. This series of pottery and the evolution of the Persians depicted on vase painting show how the Greek imagination of the Persians changed over time, and so did their idea of the East. From a formidable foe to pathetic comic reliefs, with their iconography subverted, the Persians depicted by Greek artists lost their agency over time. Classical Greek vase paintings thus capture the ancient roots of the “Mirage”, and how an artist’s biases affect the resulting depiction of the Middle East.¹⁵

Just as Said noted in *Orientalism*, the roots of the mirage go back to ancient Greece. Greek Vase Paintings give us a rich and colorful depiction of this mirage of identity. Persians were initially depicted as an ideal counterpart of the hoplites, representing their matched strength towards each other. Yet within a decade, they came to be depicted as uncivilized barbarians fleeing from “victorious” Greeks—a striking change in perspective. Ancient Greeks utilized the dichotomy between Europe and Asia to construct their identities against the Persians. In Aeschylus’s *Persians*, Asia is described as being subservient and effeminate, under the tyrannical rule of their king Xerxes; by contrast, Europe is described as free and independent. This literary process of the Greeks distinguishing themselves from Persian barbarians reveals the ancient root of creating European identity in contrast to the Middle East. This dichotomy also appears in Herodotus’s *Histories*. Greeks are described as fully armored with formidable weaponry, while Persians are portrayed as unarmored or even “fighting naked.” However, this depiction clearly reflects a bias toward an Athenian audience, given that Herodotus was writing and presenting his work in Athens. Recognizing this artist and literary construct allows us to see how the mirage of the Middle East has been used and exploited since ancient times. Since the Greek victory over the Persians, the mirage has been fundamental in

establishing Greek, and later Western, identity against the grain of the “barbarian” Middle East.

The Ilkhanate

When the Greeks were constructing their identity as free, independent, and skilled warriors against what they deemed as effeminate, submissive, and weak Persians, the Middle East was a faraway world foreign to the Greeks. The continent of Asia became an exotic, foreign, distant land to the minds of these Greek artists and writers. Then how does the mirage function when you’re inside the Middle East? The Mongol experience of the Middle East, from the 13th to 14th Centuries CE, is a unique chapter in the history of the mirage. Although the Mongol Empire stretched from the steppe of Ukraine to the Korean peninsula, this second case study will focus on the “Ilkhanate”, a modern term referring to the Middle Eastern “wing” of the wider Mongol empire.

From the ashes of conquests, the Mongols constructed a new ideology based on the Islamic and Persian traditions of the lands they now ruled. The new Mongols' identity justified their rule over the Middle East by adopting and embracing the cultural practices and ideology of the previous empires in the region. Within the Middle East, the Mongols were thus creating their own “mirage”. Research for this creation of a new Mongol identity is indebted to the rich description left behind by the Persian courtiers under the auspices of the Mongol khans. Court members such as Rashid al-Din and Ata-Malik Juvayni composed histories of the Mongol empire from the unification of the Mongol tribes by Chingghis Khan to the conquest of the Middle East by his descendants. Their language, although raw and gruesome when it comes to describing the destruction of cities and mass murder at the hands of the Mongols, glorifies the Mongol rulers with almost hagiographical allure. Beyond their epic portrayal of the Mongol khans, these courtiers would borrow from previous Persian epic poetry of ancient kings and heroes to “localize” the foreign Mongol rulers as rightful conquerors.

Literature thus played a powerful role in forging new identities and justifying conquest for the Mongol Ilkhanate. In *Culture and Imperialism*, Said interpreted imperialism that unconsciously appeared in modern British

literature, written when Britain was the empire on which the sun never set. He argued how literature became a powerful tool of justification for imperialism among these modern British authors. Said argued: “The power to narrate, or to block other narratives from forming and emerging, is very important to culture and imperialism, and constitutes one of the main connections between them.”¹⁶ This power of literature was not unnoticed by the courtier-historians of the Ilkhanate. With ancient Persian epic poetry and Islamic heritage at their disposal, these historians constructed a unique narrative of the Mongol rule and conquests that formed the new mirage of power in the Ilkhanate.

In *History of the World Conqueror*, Juvayni chronicles the Mongol invasion of the Middle East, where it began with the murder of Mongol emissaries that ignited Chingghis Khan’s ire. Chingghis Khan sought to open trade relations with the then-master of Iran and Central Asia, the Khwarezmian Empire. When a group of Mongol emissaries arrived at the Khwarezmian city of Ortar, the governor of Ortar executed them. He took their gifts over a personal drama, with the sanction of the Khwarezmshah, Muhammad II.¹⁷ What followed was the full rage of Chingghis Khan and the Mongol invasion of the Khwarezmian empire, and the Mongol conquest of Central Asia and Iran. Juvayni’s description of the Mongol conquests is full of detailed violence and destruction. After the setting fire on the Transoxianian city of Bukhara and overcoming its citadels, Juvayni recorded that “no male was spared who stood higher than the butt of a whip and more than thirty thousand were counted amongst the slain; whilst their small children, the children of their nobles and their womenfolk, slender as the reduced to slavery.” And the site of the town was reduced to “a level plain” Juvayni also recorded an eyewitness account of the Mongol invasion. A survivor of the siege of Bukhara described the Mongols as: “They came, they sapped, they burnt, they slew, they plundered and they departed.”¹⁸

The Middle Eastern areas conquered by the Mongols were later coalesced into one regime known as the Ilkhanate. The founder of the Ilkhanate was Hulegu Khan, a grandson of Chingghis Khan. When his brother Mongke Khan came to power, Hulegu was sent to the Middle East to further the Mongol conquests. Hulegu’s expansion in the Middle East reached its zenith in 1258 with the siege of Baghdad, the capital of the Abbasid caliphate. Despite this ostentatious feat of conquest, Hulegu’s westward expansion was checked by the

Mamluks of Egypt. In 1260, at the Battle of Ain Jalut in modern-day Israel, Hulegu's army was resoundingly defeated. A civil war also hindered Hulegu's expansion effort in the Middle East. The sudden death of Mongke and the following civil wars among prominent Mongol leaders also distracted Hulegu from the westward expansion. Hulegu's domain in the Middle East was challenged by other Mongol rulers, such as Berke to the North in Russia. And during the Toluid civil war, a war among the sons of Tolui that obviously included himself, Hulegu took the side of Kublai. When Kublai triumphed over his contender, Ariq Boke, and became the Great Khan, Hulegu began styling himself as the "ilkhan", a subordinate to the Great Khan. Hulegu's domain in the Middle East was thus established as the "Ilkhanate".¹⁹ The title "ilkhan", meaning "subordinate khan", is under much scholarly contention. Although the term "ilkhan" and the suffix "il-" were in use in Central Asia before the Mongol conquests, the traditional narrative is that Hulegu adopted the title of ilkhan towards 1260 as he made the Middle East his personal domain within the Mongol empire. The theories behind Hulegu's adoption of this humble title range from legitimacy to allegiance. Iran was not included in the original territories distributed by Chingghis Khan to his sons, so there could have been an issue with the lack of legitimacy in ruling Iran. The title could also denote Hulegu's original position within the greater Mongol empire as an agent of his brother and the Great Khan Mongke.²⁰ Or perhaps Hulegu was bolstering his allegiance to the new Great Khan Kublai by proclaiming to be his subordinate with the title of "subordinate khan".

Despite their rule over the Muslim-majority Middle East and having many muslims in their court, the early Ilkhans, since Hulegu were not muslims, and instead practiced either Buddhism or traditional Mongol paganism. Hulegu himself was a devout Buddhist who constructed a Buddhist temple near Lake Van, modern-day Turkey, and many more in Azerbaijan. And several eyewitness accounts, ranging from European travelers to courtiers of the Ilkhanate, including Juvayini and Rashid al-Din, report the presence of Buddhist temples and communities in the Ilkhanate. Due to this favoritism and benefaction towards Buddhism, the early Ilkhanate naturally experienced a religious conflict between Buddhists and Muslims, as reported by Juvayni.²¹ This conflict often included the suppression of certain Sufi orders, the mystical and ascetic practitioners of Buddhism. The most bloody incident was when Hulegu encountered and perplexed himself in the presence of Qalandar sufis. After

learning their philosophy and identities from his trusted advisor and a Shi'ite scholar, Nasir al-Din al-Tusi, he executed them instantly. The only outlier among the early Ilkhans was Teguder Ahmad, son of Hulegu. Teguder converted to Islam in mysterious circumstances, hinting that “Teguder's contact with sufis of the more extreme nature and their influence over him” led to him being the first Mongol ruler in Iran to convert to Islam. Teguder's legacy was cut short, however. After overthrowing Teguder, Arghun returned to the conventional religious practices with an “anti-Islamic” platform.²²

Ghazan Khan's conversion to Islam in 1295 ultimately re-fashioned the Ilkhanate into an Islamic empire. The catalyst of Ghazan's conversion is unclear, but many historians speculate that it was political pragmatism over genuine religious motivation that made conversion attractive to Ghazan. As Amitali-Preiss stated, “his [Ghazan's] motivation appears to have been an amalgam of conviction and political reasons”.²³ And as if to prove Ghazan's success in his religious policy, contemporary historians enthusiastically praised Ghazan's conversion as a momentous occasion in the Ilkhanate's history.²⁴ This conversion of the Ilkhans into Islam under Ghazan Khan in 1295 and the following construction of a new identity in the Ilkhanate signifies another aspect of the Middle East as a mirage of identity. Despite the savage destruction and loss of life throughout Iran and Central Asia brought upon by the Mongols, the Mongol Ilkhanate eventually combined the Mongol imperial ideology and traditional Persian model of kingship that produced a new, unique ideology of the Ilkhans and that of the “Iran-zamin”. From nomadic, pagan invaders to the Islamic and legitimate rulers of Iran, the Mongol Ilkhans now adopted a new identity in the Middle East. The term Iran-zamin means “Land of Iran” in Persian. Iran-zamin is not simply a physical or geographic region of Iran; rather, it refers back to the ancient idea of Iran as an imperial state. Melville emphasized the centuries of disunity and political struggle in Iran before the arrival of the Mongols. Iran enjoyed a rich tradition of kingship far before the advent of Islam. And the Sasanian empire (3rd-7th Century CE) firmly established the notion of “Iranshahr”, the domain of Iran. But since the collapse of the Sasanian empire, various local and foreign dynasties vied for supremacy in Iran, with no single power uniting the region. The ancient idea of Iran as a coherent culture grouping or a state ceased to exist politically by the 12th Century. Only a few poets and writers recounted the ancient heritage of Iranian kingship and the Iranian state.²⁵ In an ironic twist of history, it was the foreign

Mongols who united all of the Iranian plateau. Their complete rule over Iran would lead to the development of *iran-zamin*.

Historians in the Ilkhanate court wrote the history of the Mongols in conjunction with the wider world history, but especially within the context of Iranian history. They were writing a new history of the Mongols, where the Mongols weren't foreign invaders to Iran but rather legitimate successors to the Iranian kingship and its heritage. In doing so, the Ilkhanate incorporated their Mongol ancestors into the wider mythos of legendary Persian kings and heroes. Written by the Persian poet Ferdowsi around the year 1000 CE, *Shahnameh* (Book of Kings) recounts the deeds and battles of mythical Iranian kings and heroes of a bygone era. So central to the Persian cultural consciousness, the *Shahnameh* proved to be the prime source material used by the Ilkhanate's historians to legitimize the Mongol rule in the Middle East. Juvayni himself often quoted the poetic lines of the *Shahnameh* in his *History of the World Conqueror*. When Chingghis Khan is attacking the great Transoxanian city of Samarkand, he quotes lines from the *Shahnameh* as an analogy to the conqueror's aura that rendered his enemies impotent.²⁶ The Mongol Ilkhans would also commission their own editions of *Shahnameh*. The so-called *Great Mongol Shahnameh* is the shining example of this Ilkhanid literary practice. The volume is a richly illustrated copy of the *Shahnameh* with new artistic motifs brought from the wider cultural sphere that was the Mongol Empire. Commissioned and illustrated in the late Ilkhanate period, around 1330s, the *Great Mongol Shahnameh* boasts 280 large folios and 190 illustrations.²⁷ This construction of a new imperial identity and legitimization of imperialism through literature echoes back to Said's critique of the relationship between British imperialism and literature mentioned above. Adorned with verses from the *Shahnameh* and fabulous illustrations, the courtier-historians of the Ilkhanate shrouded the new dynasty with a new "mirage" that illuminated Mongol imperialism in the Middle East.

Beyond literature, this new identity of the Mongols in the Middle East is also reflected in physical materials. Takht-e Soleyman, a UNESCO World Heritage site, stands as a physical attestment to this new style of Mongol rule. The site was already a sacred place during the Sasanian era, where a Zoroastrian fire temple once stood. The Ilkhans would build their own palace at Takht-e Soleyman, reinvigorating the ancient ground plan.²⁸ The ancient ruins of the old

site were rebuilt as a summer palace with a completely new style under the Ilkhanate. The archaeological excavation at Takht-e Soleyman yielded thousands of decorative tiles with vibrant colors and motifs from both ancient Iranian and Chinese art. Some tiles would feature ancient Iranian kings from the *Shahnameh*, while those inspired by Chinese art depict dragons and phoenixes in Chinese style.²⁹ The Ilkhanate's deliberate choice of the previous Sasanian temple site as a summer palace and the incorporation of ancient Iranian and Chinese motifs into their official art are material embodiments of the Ilkhanate's effort to forge a new identity in the Middle East.

The usage of previous civilizations' legacies, adopting powerful motifs and cultural achievements of the predecessors to elevate the current conqueror's ambition and legitimize their rule, seems to be a patterned behavior among conquerors. Said's comments on the various European experiences of Egypt during Napoleon's invasion resemble a striking parallel with the Mongol experience of the Middle East. Again, in *Orientalism*, Said points out how Napoleon sought to appeal to the Islamic sensibilities of the Egyptians while he occupied the country, such as translating everything he said in Quranic Arabic or inviting local religious authorities to his camps for honors.³⁰ The various scholars who accompanied Napoleon's expedition, the naturalists, archaeologists, and historians alike, praised Egypt while simultaneously mourning the current state of the country as "Barbarism." These European scholars thus justified the military domination of Egypt to acquire its ancient knowledge and absorb it into the modern European civilization. Said critiques this reasoning as reducing Egyptian history, and thus wider Oriental history, relegating it to a more general "world history."³¹ An uncanny resemblance appears here, as the courtier-historians of the Ilkhanate also wrote "world history" with the Mongol khans as the center figure of the narrative and rightful conquerors. The conqueror's effort to use religious legitimacy to placate the conquered populace in the late 18th century, and reducing the history of the preceding civilizations to justify conquest, invokes a similar effort used in the 14th Century by a not-so-different conqueror. Said's investigation of Napoleon's conquest of Egypt in *Orientalism* thus proved itself to be highly relevant to our understanding of constructing identity in the Middle East. Much like Napoleon almost 500 years later, the Ilkhanate was creating a new identity as the rightful, Islamic rulers of the Middle East.

The Ilkhanate did not last long. Ruling much of Iran, Iraq, and the Caucasus for less than a 100 years, the Mongol state soon fragmented into regional Mongol warlords. Despite this short tenure, the Ilkhanate is still a crucial page of the history of identity in the Middle East. In conjunction with Said's comparative study of imperialism and literary culture, the Mongol Ilkhanate saw the construction of a new identity where ancient Iranian kingship is tied with the Mongol conquerors to justify and even glorify the Mongol rulers. The Ilkhans and their courtiers thus created a new "mirage" of identity inside the Middle East, combining motifs from both the old and new.

Gulf States

So far, this essay has covered how identity was being created inside and outside of the Middle East and traced the process of how identity was being constructed in each circumstance. In modern Gulf States, however, the preconceived notion of the Middle East as the "exotic other" is projected outward, thriving in various commercials and tourism adverts to promote tourists, especially Western tourists, to come visit and spend money along the shores of the Gulf. Modern tourism adverts in the Middle East openly embrace orientalist stereotypes that Said critiqued as reductionary. Intersecting between the expectations and reality, these commercials shed light on contemporary Orientalism. Often used to demean Middle Eastern culture, these nations ironically decided to take advantage of this prejudice to allure Western audiences for tourism.

Although the Gulf States, such as Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and the UAE, experienced both contact and conflict with Western nations since the 19th Century, their strong economic ties with the West only began during the 1940s. As the British Empire exited from the Middle East in the 20th Century, the United States inherited its role as a regional "policeman", forming strong ties with various Gulf States. The US entrance into the Gulf began when the United States recognized Saudi Arabia as a key partner right before its entrance into the Second World War, when oil consumption for shipping and military vehicles rapidly increased compared to the First World War. The US would gain control over the vast oil reserves of Saudi Arabia, while guaranteeing its security with military bases. Other Gulf states soon entered the fold of the US as the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan and the Iranian revolution in 1979 threatened US

security in the Gulf. And Saddam Hussein's invasion of Kuwait in 1990 further strengthened the US involvement in the Gulf region.³²

This close relationship with Western nations allowed the skyrocketing growth of the capitalist economy among the Gulf States. Similar to the Ilkhanate, these Gulf States blended their cultural identity, resulting in the creation of a capitalistic monarchy. This unlikely combination of autocracy and free market economy can be examined through the UAE's investment and tax policies. In the case of investment policies, the UAE, especially Abu Dhabi, channels oil revenues into diverse global markets such as real estate, equities, bonds, and infrastructure. Known as sovereign wealth investments, Abu Dhabi Investment Authority, the ADIA, is one of the largest sovereign wealth funds in the world. Additionally, the UAE has opened itself to foreign investors by establishing "free zones," allowing for complete foreign ownership of properties. These specialized zones, such as Dubai Media City and Internet City, pulled in multinational corporations. This rapidly growing free economy of the UAE is imbued in its tax policies. For decades, apart from the oil companies and foreign banks, the emirates had no personal income tax nor federal corporate tax, making the nation highly attractive for investors and expatriates. It was only in 2023 when the UAE finally introduced a federal corporate tax on business profits above USD \$100,000. The UAE's investment and tax policies combine state-driven global investment, sovereign wealth funds, with business-friendly and low tax environments that elicit foreign attraction.³³ This flexible and diversified economic policy of the UAE attracts many foreign investors to the country and simultaneously seeks "foreign direct investment (FDI)" as well.³⁴

The rapidly growing and diversifying economy of the UAE is just one example of how the Gulf States are attracting foreign investors to contribute to their economy and elevate themselves as prominent players in the global economy. But this new and important role came with the need to establish the state's identity. Just as the advent of the Mongol Empire and the reorganization of the Middle Eastern territories into the Ilkhanate required the construction of a new identity, the growing importance of the Gulf States also urged these burgeoning economies to question how they would represent themselves to the world, and especially towards their Western partners. The following examples

from the UAE, specifically Dubai, Qatar, and Saudi Arabia, showcase how the Gulf States are using orientalist “mirage” to target Western audiences.

Various tourism commercials produced by the Gulf States, usually targeted towards Western audiences, show how the Gulf States have fully embraced the stereotypical orientalist imagery to their advantage. The Dubai Tour advertisement is a great example of modern exploitation of Orientalism. In *Dubai: If You Go, You Know*, the narrator explains and displays various sceneries and leisure activities in Dubai. At the same time, the subtle usage of “Middle Eastern” imagery reflects their purpose in fulfilling the Western audience’s biases. These hints are portrayed through the constant appearance of outdoor events in desert scenery, including desert safaris, sandboarding, and riding camels. Back in the city area, tourists are seen at the souks, traditional Arab marketplaces selling elaborate carpets, textiles, and jewelry. The stereotypical and exotic Middle Eastern imagery offered by the Dubai Tour implies who the designated audience is and the main purpose of commercializing this representation of Dubai. In other words, this promotional video wouldn’t be advertising the ‘Middle Eastern’ aspect of Dubai to the domestic audience. In fact, when the video exhibits beautiful scenery throughout the city, the narrator repeatedly stresses, “Dubai is home. Home for many”.³⁵ It is evident that the protagonists of the commercial are supposed to be foreign tourists, written to represent Dubai as ‘home’ for both foreigners and locals alike. Not dissimilar to the 19th-century Western orientalist literature that Said critiqued in *Orientalism*, the narrator of the advert presents the Western perspective on Middle Eastern culture, reflected through the Western tourists. Though some aspects, such as the emphasis on outdoor activities made for tourists, were exaggerated to entice Western audiences, the depiction of traditional architectural designs and arab merchandise shown through the bazaar scene corresponds to the stereotypes Westerners hold in perceiving the Middle East. As such, this commercial takes advantage of Orientalism, weakening the strong boundary between reality and the “mirage” of the Middle East.³⁶

The 2022 Qatar World Cup also saw the usage of orientalist Middle Eastern imagery to the advantage of a Gulf state amid a controversy. In 2010, Qatar won the bid to become the host of the 2022 FIFA World Cup. This successful bidding was a huge deal within the country as Qatar became the first Middle Eastern country to host the World Cup. The event itself surprised the

world as Qatar only had a population of two million and never made it through World Cup qualifiers. Yet, for the Qataris, hosting the World Cup was an opportunity to promote their nation to the world audience.³⁷ But even before the opening ceremony of the Qatar World Cup, the choice of Qatar as a host was surrounded by a myriad of controversies. Issues of human rights violations of foreign workers in Qatar, as well as allegations of corruption and bribery in the bidding process, arose. Former FIFA president Sepp Blatter admitted it was a “mistake”. Reported by NPR, Blatter said, “I was responsible for that as president at the time”.³⁸ In response, Qatar and FIFA maintained that there was no evidence for their wrongdoing, but the concerns remained about Qatar being the host country for the 2022 World Cup. In response to this controversial bribery, protests from various clubs and countries arose around the world. However, the journalists Tariq Panja and Kevin Draper reported, “after years of investigations and indictments, the United States Department of Justice on Monday said for the first time that representatives working for ...Qatar had bribed FIFA officials to secure hosting rights for the World Cup in men’s soccer”. As an account, they posited that the crucial determining factor in Qatar’s bidding process was the billions of dollars that were already invested in building the World Cup stadium over other competing nations, such as the United States. This revelation of Qatar’s bribery resolved one of the many controversies surrounding the 2022 World Cup.³⁹

Human rights violations also came to the public's attention as the opening of the 2022 Qatar World Cup approached. The issue has been persistent throughout the 2010s, since Qatar won the bid, and long before the World Cup. A 2021 Guardian analysis reported that more than 6,500 migrant workers, mainly from South Asia, have died since Qatar was announced as the host in 2010.⁴⁰ As a noticeable amount of foreign laborers passed away from harsh weather conditions as well as from poor living conditions, the outside world began to call out Qatar over these abusive working conditions. Qatar’s human rights violations didn’t end on that note. Pardoning themselves for religiosity, Qatar banned the audience from expressing their sexual identities, clearly showing their hostility towards LGBTQ+ community. On this issue, Al Marri and Hind Al Ansari notes, “while the Western media considered the banning of alcohol and the refusal to display the slogan ‘OneLove’ to be violations of the individual’s freedom of expression, many members of the Arab and Muslim audiences considered these same [issues] to represent a firm commitment to

their religious beliefs and cultural values”.⁴¹ These controversial convictions of Qatar and its citizens are attributed to the dilemmas that surrounded the 2022 World Cup.

Qatar was thus facing a great marketing disaster for its upcoming World Cup. And their effort to obscure these issues is evident in their promotional ads. In “The Official FIFA World Cup Qatar 2022™ Theme| FIFA World Cup 2022 Soundtrack”, the commercial begins with the entrance of a flying magic carpet emerging from the sand dunes. After the appearance of the carpet, the scene shifts to Qatari boys playing soccer surrounded by desert with Arabic scripts engraved in the sand. Subsequently, the traditional Qatari architecture appears with the locals celebrating the World Cup, while flags of various countries are displayed in the background. After the magic carpet visits the 2022 Qatar World Cup stadium, the advertisement ends with the appearance of “FIFA World Cup Qatar 2022”.⁴² While Qatar may emphasize the authenticity of their culture in this commercial, the country also curated aspects of fictionalized Arab culture that would feel exotic or mystical to the outside audience, especially western audiences, echoing deeply rooted orientalist tropes. These usages can be clearly shown through the image of the desert, falcon, conventional Arab architecture, and the flying carpet. Qatar strategically used the World Cup to not only showcase football and promote the event itself, but also exaggerate authentic Arab culture with fiction to create an exotic image for the world audience, putting the controversies under the carpet.

Similar to Dubai’s futuristic landscape, Saudi Arabia pursues rapid modernization throughout its much larger territory. This vigor towards construction can be shown through the recent Neom project, a futuristic megaproject in northwest Saudi Arabia that aims to build a high-tech, sustainable planned city.⁴³ At the same time, the nation sustains its fame as the birthplace of Islam and home to Islam's two holiest cities, Mecca and Medina. Saudi Arabia is thus a great case study of Said’s Orientalism in its modern applications. This representation of Said’s definition of Orientalism can be mirrored through the tourism commercial of Saudi Arabia. As a sentinel of the two holy cities with a rapidly growing modern economy, Saudi Arabia seeks to flaunt both its “oriental” heritage and the ability to build massive infrastructure. In *Welcome to Saudi Tourism and Saudi Arabia*, the video emphasizes ancient ruins, bustling modern cities, and snapshots of various biomes within the

kingdom. The narrator revolves around the notion of innovation, as well as delving into exotic areas of Saudi Arabia that the audience has never experienced. The scenery shown in the commercial, including deserts, oceans, and mountains, highlights Saudi Arabia as not just a desert, but a place of beauty, diversity, and adventure. Shifting to the cultural aspect of the advertisement, the history of the kingdom is imbued within the video through the entrance of various ancient sites, such as Hegra, Saudi Arabia's first UNESCO World Heritage Site. Additionally, blending with the cultural heritage of Saudi Arabia, the commercial successfully promotes the urban sophistication of the kingdom. This harmony between the past and the future is portrayed through the scene where Western tourist couples are having a fine dining experience with an ancient ruin as a backdrop. Through the demonstration of various landscapes of the kingdom, this blend rebrands Saudi Arabia as not a closed conservative monarchy it is in reality, but a place that holds both ancient heritage as well as contemporary accommodations for tourists.⁴⁴ Interestingly, the commercial *Welcome to Saudi Tourism and Saudi Arabia* operates in an inverted Orientalist mode. Instead of portraying the kingdom through a Western Orientalist lens, such as the mystical desert and Oasis, Saudi Arabia curates the authentic aspects of the nation by focusing on its natural scenery and ancient ruins. Yet, similarly to Orientalism filtering reality to create a fantastical "East", the Saudi tourism video filters its own reality, presenting a curated blend of heritage and modernity while avoiding social or political complexities. The commercial repackages Orientalism rather than holistically rejecting stereotypical imagery. The video invites Western tourists to consume a Saudi Arabia that is carefully crafted by both exotic, such as ancient ruins and vast terrains, and familiar, including modern applications and cuisine.

Said's Orientalism provides a piercing interpretation of the imagery portrayed in these various Gulf States' commercials. The irony lies in the "Middle Eastern" Gulf States using stereotypical imagery to promote themselves to the Western audience. The Gulf States are "buying into" Orientalism, so to speak. Alluding to the exoticism of their country throughout the video, the Dubai Tour advertisement exemplifies Said's notion by the appearance of anticipated Middle Eastern imagery, including camel riding in the desert as well as depiction of traditional souks. This archetype reaches its pinnacle in the 2022 Qatar World Cup commercial. Amidst the controversy over human rights violations in the country, Qatar was in need of rehabilitating its

national image. Their promotional video starts and ends with the appearance of the flying magic carpet, painting a fantastical view of the country, accompanied by a grain of reality with conventional Qatari architecture in the background. Subtly deviating from the previous commercials, which heavily conceded to a Western perspective, *Welcome to Saudi Tourism and Saudi Arabia* posits a different approach, with Western tourists enjoying the various heritage of the kingdom as the centerpiece of their advert. While Said criticized the Orient featured in Western literature as a place to be conquered by the Western protagonist, these tourism commercials invert Said's critique on its head. The Orient is now a land of exotic scenery and culture, not to be conquered, but to spend holidays in. The outward projection of the Middle Eastern scenery of the Gulf States' tourism commercials thus exemplifies a modern application of the "mirage". The orientalist imagery that Western authors used to reduce the Middle East to a place of conquest is now working to the advantage of these Middle Eastern countries.

Conclusion

What we thought of as timeless and primordial perception of certain parts of the world when learning history, from ancient to modern, often turns out to be a fairly modern and artificial construction. Writers, rulers, and artists alike all contributed to creating a new identity and perception of the world to justify their rule or cement their place in the world. Their view of the world varies throughout history. From the perspective of the outsiders, conquerors, and natives, the process of constructing identity has shown how our conception of the Middle East was fluid and artificial: a "mirage" throughout history. In exploring this mirage, Edward Said's *Orientalism* and *Culture and Imperialism* served as essential critiques. Just as the Western authors in Said's work were creating their image of the "Orient" throughout the 19th and 20th centuries, the subjects of this essay all contributed to the "mirage" in their own ways.

In the Ancient World, the Greeks, by defeating the twin invasions of the Persian kings, Darius and Xerxes, established a dichotomy between what they perceived as the masculine, independent West and the effeminate, submissive East. This polarizing view of the two worlds is most apparent in their vase paintings, where the Greek artists made sure to depict the Persians in weak, defeated poses. Simultaneously, the Persian invasion brought an immense

impact on the Greek view of their past myths as well. The ancient kings and heroes of Troy were now depicted with Persian clothing and iconography, denoting their “Asianess” that distinguished them from the “European” Achaean heroes.

The Medieval period also saw the molding of a new identity, this time inside the Middle East, through the Mongol invasion. The Mongol Ilkhanate, in order to justify their rule over the Middle East, crossbred their lineage as nomadic conquerors with the Islamic faith and ancient Iranian kingship. The Mongol rulers were thus able to maintain their nomadic, steppe identity while inserting themselves into the Islamic milieu of their new subjects. The physical monuments of their rule, most notably Takht-e Solayman, embodied this new and pluralistic identity of the “ilkhans”. The richly decorated tiles of Takht-e Solayman, with paintings of ancient Iranian kings and Chinese dragons on them, show the vast array of motifs the artists of the Ilkhanate could absorb into their imperial narrative. The Mongol ilkhans thus encapsulate how new identities can be forged within the Middle East.

The contemporary Gulf States, such as Saudi Arabia, Qatar, and the UAE, twist the often negative, orientalist stereotypes to their advantage. Enjoying friendly and strategic relationships with the West, especially the United States, has given them a rare opportunity to pander to Westerners. The various adverts and promotional videos produced by these Gulf States revel in orientalist imagery to promote themselves towards western tourists, showcasing the vast desert scenery in conjunction with their highrises and sophisticated planned-cities. What was once a simplistic and sometimes offensive idea of the Middle East is now a marketing gimmick for tourism.

Tracing this shifting idea, from 500 BCE to the 21st Century, can enlighten us moderns to view other ideas that have a similar history, or prevent potential conflict over identity. The history of the idea of the Middle East has shown how malleable our conception of the world is. Perhaps this critical view towards dominant notions of the world can further our study of history and shed light on the wider “mirage” of our time. In this day and age, when the Middle East is endlessly featured in our news and mass media, recognizing the “mirage” of the Middle East could help us see through that thick mist of our own imaginations.

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